

MANMOHAN SINGH WILL HE BE FIT TO LEAD?

The unprecedented situation of a government without a singular point of authority following the prime minister's heart surgery on the eve of a crucial general election brings out the fear and paranoia of the Congress leadership structure

| By Prabhu Chawla with Priya Sahgal |

That could have been a photo-op that warmed a billion hearts. On January 23, when the prime minister's motorcade entered the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), New Delhi, Manmohan Singh was expected to wave at the cameras and say a few words to the media that would have reassured the nation that there was nothing frighteningly wrong with the good doctor and that he was still in high spirits. A bureaucratic goof-up denied India—and the Congress party—that trademark smile of the prime minister who has been leading a 12-party coalition Government with understated confidence for 56 eventful months. His sudden hospitalisation and a complex, 12-hour-long surgery for correcting five coronary blockages has not only raised fresh questions about his fitness to lead but exposed a Congress leadership structure built on fear and paranoia.

What else could explain the absence of a singular point of authority in the wake of the prime minister's surgery? Though senior officials like his Principal Secretary T.K. Nair, National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan and Cabinet Secretary K.M. Chandrasekhar were told about the surgery, none of them was specifically informed about the nature of succession or the new chain of command. There were no precedents and there were hardly any conventions which the previous 12 prime ministers had followed. The problem of naming a successor could have been avoided but for certain ceremonial

Duty ROSTER

Instead of one second in command, the prime minister has opted for a wide-spread allocation of his duties

As senior-most minister, Pranab Mukherjee will chair Cabinet meetings. Has also been allocated the finance portfolio.

A standing order identifying the nuclear chain of command in the PM's absence is in place but has not been made public.

A.K. Antony stepped in for the prime minister for all Republic Day functions. In Mukherjee's absence he gets to be in charge.